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SETTING THE PACE ED director Rahul Navin at a conference in Delhi

ANI

▶ ENFORCEMENT DIRECTORATE

CHARGESHEET BLITZ

The agency ramps up chargesheets and asset returns, rebuilding its investigative credibility

By MUNISH CHANDRA PANDEY

ON MAY 17, 2019, THE ENFORCEMENT DIRECTORATE (ED) lodged a money-laundering case against former Haryana chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda, in connection with corruption charges allegedly involving the coerced sale of about 1,417 acres of land across sectors 58 to 67 of Gurugram at below-market rates. The case followed a trajectory that has come to define the agency: raids conducted, headlines generated, assets attached—and then, silence.

This March, the ED finally filed a chargesheet—formally known as a prosecution complaint (PC)—against Hooda at a special court for Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) cases, bringing to a close to an investigation that spanned six long years.

Hooda's case is not an outlier. It is the latest example of sweeping changes that Rahul Navin, director of ED, is enforcing in the way the directorate proceeds with its cases. Officers say that he has got the agency to act on a war footing and file chargesheets in the over 6,000 pending cases it is investigating so that they can reach the court and trial can begin. This was after the ED faced tremendous criticism, especially by the Opposition parties, for a glaring structural gap: it was swift to register cases and attach assets, but chronically slow to bring matters to trial. In the nine years between 2005 and 2014, it filed a mere 84 PCs—fewer than 10 a year. Even between 2014 and 2024, the annual average was 132. Experts say there was also a darker dimension to the institutional backlog.